

# Fruit caviar

Saturday, April 26, 2025

19:33

- **Time:** 2 hours
- **Difficulty:** very challenging, special ingredients needed

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## For the berry puree

### Ingredients:

- 1 punnet strawberries (or another fruit – adjust sugar and acid to taste)
- 2 tablespoons caster sugar
- 1 teaspoon lemon juice
- $\frac{1}{8}$  teaspoon Calcium Lactate Gluconate Powder (2 g per 100 ml)
- Xanthan Gum Powder (if required 0.2 g to 0.5 g per 100 ml)

### Method:

- Place fruit and sugar in a pot on the stove top and heat until sugar starts to caramelize and fruit is soft.
- Pass through sieve to remove seeds.
- Set aside to cool (should be a bit over  $\frac{1}{2}$  cup – approx 125 ml).
- Add Xanthan gum if not thick enough – it needs to be the consistency of thick cream (0.2 g per 100 ml turns something with water consistency into a cream-like consistency – 0.5 g per 100 ml will make a cheesecake-like consistency).
- Add calcium lactate gluconate and mix thoroughly (though not so much that froth is formed – I have a teeny-weeny whisk for this).
- Leave to rest.

## For the sodium alginate water bath

### Ingredients:

- 5 g icing sugar
- 5 g Sodium Alginate Powder (0.5%, or 5 g per litre water)
- 1000 ml distilled water

### Method:

- Mix the icing sugar and sodium alginate together and place in the bowl of an immersion blender with half the distilled water.
- Blend for at least one minute. Then add the rest of the distilled water.
- Pour into large clear pyrex bowl, cover with cling film and leave in the fridge to rest for at least 4 hours to remove the air bubbles (recommend 1 – 24 hours).

## To make the magic

- Set up a bowl of fresh water next to the sodium alginate bath.
- Fill a syringe with the berry compote/calcium.
- Place the barrel of the syringe into the sodium alginate bath and slowly and carefully dispense a droplet under the liquid while raising the syringe towards the surface.
- Let the little spheres fall to the bottom of the bowl and gently tease with a spoon so all the surfaces get exposed to the water bath.
- Alternatively (for larger spheres), fill a 1 teaspoon measuring spoon and carefully pour out right over the surface.
- These larger spheres will form as they penetrate the water bath due to surface tension. Allow the spheres to fall to the bottom (or 'help' them sink with some gentle agitation).
- If the fruit mixture just spreads across the surface, then it is too thin – use some Xanthan gum to thicken it up a bit.
- Leave the spheres in the sodium alginate for a couple of minutes to form a solid gel membrane and 'set', then carefully remove with a slotted spoon and rinse in the water bath.
- Scoop spheres out of the water bath to a clean container

Scop spheres out of the water bath to a clean container.

- The spheres can be used immediately, or set aside until needed by storing in liquid to prevent them drying out. Store the caviar in a solution of fruit juice (same as what they are made from), rather than water – or they will dilute due to the wonders of osmosis.



strawberry fruit 'spheres', or shapes

#### **Now some hints:**

1) Do you really need distilled water? Probably not, especially if your tap water is not too hard – Canberra's water is typically quite soft. However, I've use distilled water with good results. It's about \$3 a litre in BigW.

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2) Never try to hydrate the sodium alginate in warm water!

3) I have had great success doing reverse spherification with diary products, such as yoghurt and cheesecake, though I still add calcium to help with a firm gel membrane.

4) Bigger spheres can have a strange 'mouth feel' when they burst in your mouth compared to small (pea sized) caviar – that's my opinion (I think it's the thickness of the membrane required to hold together a larger sphere). I never try to make anything bigger than a grape, unless it's just for show and breaking over something